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My Mother and Literacy

One of my earliest memories of reading is of my mother sitting beside me at night with a book in her hands. When I was a child, I had trouble falling asleep, so she would read English stories to me. I did not understand every word, and I was often more interested in the pictures, but those nights were my first introduction to English and reading.

My mother is a professor of English in Nepal and has been teaching for around twenty-five years. Since I grew up seeing her as a professor, it always seemed normal to me. I never really thought about how she became one. She would leave for college, come home, read books, prepare for classes, and talk about her students. To me, that was simply what my mother did. I never thought about what she had gone through to get there.

When my mother was young, life for girls in the community was very different from life today. They were mostly expected to become wives, take care of the house, and raise children. Even basic education was not strongly encouraged for girls, and pursuing higher education was like chasing a mirage.

My mother had always loved reading and was a bright student. However, she got married when she was nineteen, just after beginning her bachelor's degree. Marriage brought many new responsibilities, but she still wanted to continue her education. Spending too much time

reading was often seen as a waste of time, especially when a married woman was expected to focus on household work. Still, she could not give up reading.

So, she found small ways to make time for reading, even while doing household work. My family had cows, and one of her responsibilities was cutting grass to feed them. Sometimes, she would take a book with her, climb to the top of a hill to cut grass, finish the work as quickly as she could, and then sit somewhere quiet to read before going home.

At night, after everyone had gone to sleep, she would continue reading under a small light.

Reading was her passion, but almost nothing around her supported her desire to read.

So, she took a bold step. She decided to leave the village and move to Kathmandu, the capital of Nepal, with my father to continue her bachelor's degree, despite the expectations of both her community and my family. Moving to Kathmandu gave her the opportunity to continue her education and build a life beyond what society had expected of her.

She wanted to become a teacher, so after completing her bachelor's and master's degrees, she began teaching English literature. However, her difficulties did not end there. When she first started teaching, people did not take her seriously. Her colleagues, who were mostly men, mocked her, and even some students did not respect her in the same way they respected male teachers. She stood out like a poppy in a wheat field.

Experiences like these could have easily made her give up, but she continued studying and teaching. Instead of accepting what others expected from her, she kept moving forward with her education. She later earned her PhD and continued teaching for around twenty-five years. Even today, after all those years, she still reads almost every day.

Growing up with my mother shaped the way I viewed books and education. In my house, we were taught to respect books and never throw them carelessly or step on them. This respect was also part of our community and culture. Books are associated with Saraswati, the goddess of knowledge and learning, and every year during Saraswati Puja, we worship the books we read and use for studying. Because of this, books were never treated as just ordinary objects in our home.

My mother also made English part of our daily lives. Whenever I came across a new word, she encouraged me to learn its meaning instead of ignoring it. My sister and I would sometimes practice new words together and try to use them in sentences.

Those small habits slowly made English more than just a subject in school. It became part of the stories I heard, the conversations in my house, and eventually the things I began reading on my own.

Looking back, I think the most important thing my mother gave me was curiosity. Growing up, I almost always saw her with a book nearby. Because books were such a constant part of her life, I naturally became curious about them too. I wanted to know what was inside the pages she was always staring at. Over time, that curiosity became my own.

As I got older, that curiosity led me toward interests very different from my mother's. She studied English, while I became interested in mathematics, computers, and technology. Today, I may be reading about programming or artificial intelligence instead of literature, but the way I learn is still influenced by her. When I do not understand something, I keep searching, reading, and trying different explanations until it begins to make sense.

For a long time, I thought literacy simply meant knowing how to read and write. My mother's story changed that idea for me. For her, reading was more than a skill; it was independence. It

gave her the chance to continue her education and build a different future for herself. Her experience also makes me think about how different my own opportunities are and how privileged I am to have been born in this generation.

Even though we grew up in completely different times, I learned from her to keep learning and to follow what interests me. She found that through books and English; I have found it through mathematics, computers, and technology. Whenever I open a book, read an article, or try to understand a difficult concept on my computer, I think I am continuing a habit that started with her.